PROactive PRONUNCIATION

De-Stressed “A”

The word “a” is a special function word. Because it is unstressed, English speakers tend to reduce the pronunciation to a simple “uh” rather than “aa” or “ey” when a consonant follows it. The result is a quicker, more natural reduction of the word. If the word “a” is followed by a vowel, however, the “a” will be pronounced as “an.” For example, “a door” is pronounced “uh,” because there is a consonant after the word.

In the phrases below, practice reducing the word “a” to “uh,” and “an” to “uhn.”

He had a plan
I grabbed a piece of paper
We had a deal
I learned a lesson
I held a cup in my hand
She sat in a chair
We’re in a good place
That was a good decision
You had a great idea
We did a good job
What a beautiful place
Have a nice day
Have a great evening
What a day

What a great game
There’s a letter for you
I had a report due today
A paper got jammed
I need a pen
Do you have a clock here?
I need a washroom break
I need to make a decision
We had a discussion
She won a prize
What an ordeal
He’s an organized guy
I love an interesting story
That’s a plan